

Scenario Brief

Pre-Acquisition Cybersecurity Due Diligence Review
Meridian Financial Group • Acquisition of NovaPay Technologies

Engagement Snapshot

Acquirer	Meridian Financial Group
Target	NovaPay Technologies (fintech payment processor)
Deal value	\$85,000,000
Customers at risk	200,000 small businesses
Assessment window	4 weeks (pre-board sign-off)
Frameworks applied	NIST CSF 2.0, CIS Controls v8, NIST SP 800-61
Inputs provided	Vendor security questionnaire, partial network diagram, technology inventory

The Situation

Meridian Financial Group is acquiring NovaPay Technologies, a fintech startup that processes payments for 200,000 small businesses. The deal is valued at \$85 million. Meridian's security team has been given four weeks to assess NovaPay's security posture before the board signs off.

For the review, the team has been handed three inputs: a completed vendor security questionnaire, a partial network diagram, and a list of the technologies NovaPay runs. The job is to identify the risks, score them, and give the executive team a clear, business-language picture of what they are buying.

Because \$85 million and the payment data of 200,000 businesses are on the line, every technical finding in this review is tied back to a business consequence: regulatory exposure, breach liability, deal risk, or reputational damage to Meridian post-acquisition.

NovaPay Technology Stack

Fictional but realistic. Every finding in the assessment traces back to one of these facts.

Cloud infrastructure	AWS-hosted (EC2, S3, RDS)
Container platform	Kubernetes cluster running payment microservices
Source control	GitHub - mix of public and private repositories
Identity / SSO	Okta, deployed to only 60% of staff
Endpoints	Windows 10, no EDR deployed
Legacy data store	On-prem Oracle database - 3 years of transaction history
Security staffing	No dedicated security team; a single IT admin handles 'security'
Attestations	SOC 2 Type I from 18 months ago; no Type II

Compliance	PCI-DSS self-assessment (SAQ) completed, not independently audited
------------	--

Why This Matters

NovaPay is a payment processor, which places it squarely in scope for PCI DSS and makes cardholder data its most sensitive asset. The combination of a thin security function, incomplete identity controls, unmonitored endpoints, a legacy off-cloud data store, and point-in-time-only assurance means the acquisition carries material, quantifiable cybersecurity risk that the Meridian board needs to understand before close.

This is a fictional scenario created for a cybersecurity portfolio project. All companies, findings, and data are invented for training and demonstration purposes.